Turn and Talk

Structuring purposeful partner discussion

Use Turn and Talk for a short, purposeful exchange that helps students clarify or rehearse an idea. Specify the question, partner roles, time and response you will collect afterwards.

How to do it well

1 Build predictable pairs. Use stable A/B partners where possible and decide the speaking order, including a planned trio when numbers require it.

2 Give thinking time. Protect five to ten seconds—or longer—so each pupil retrieves, annotates or drafts before speaking.

3 Structure the question. Ask pupils to explain, justify, compare, predict, evaluate or rank, using content already taught or made available.

4 Provide a concrete stimulus. Anchor talk in a text, graph, model, image, worked example, data or vocabulary prompt rather than memory-free opinion.

5 Rehearse briefly and account. Use short bursts, switch speakers explicitly, stop near the crest of productive talk and cold call pupils to share or summarise.

What this sounds like

“Partner A explains which option fits; Partner B challenges the reason. Swap after thirty seconds. Afterwards I may ask you to explain your partner’s choice.”

Classroom example. In English, paired talk compares two interpretations of a line. Each partner must give a reason and respond to the other. The teacher samples the discussion, signals its end while useful talk is active and asks selected pupils to explain their partner’s reasoning. Students then refine their own written interpretation.

Top tips that make the technique work

Prime the end as well as the start. Students should know how they will stop and what answer they must be ready to give.

Stop at the crest of the wave. End while useful exchange is active rather than waiting until every pair has exhausted the prompt.

Listen for the thinking. Sample the content of talk, not merely whether pupils are speaking.

Ask about the partner. A request to restate the other person’s reasoning creates listening accountability.

Re-vote individually where appropriate. After comparing ideas, students commit again so you can see changed thinking.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Set a specific cognitive question and clear roles.	“Discuss this” with no product or purpose.
Harvest the discussion deliberately.	Letting one partner deliver both contributions.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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